

# EDITORS' COLUMN

## **Our Words (and Actions) Must Grow**

### **Introduction**

We share this special issue of courageous essays on antiracist teaching and writing methods by US-based educators in a period of entwined war zones—in which antiracism, anti-sexism, solidarity with the people of Palestine and Lebanon and Iran, community defense against ICE abductions and murders, queer and trans life affirmation, healthcare and social welfare access, and much more are under attack by a vicious, neo-fascist regime. As in past roiling generations, the university—and the writing classroom within it—is a contradictory convergence space: it's both a haven for critical thought and action, and a battering ram to demolish these hallowed practices. It's both an engine for collective emancipatory horizons, and an enforcer of colonial extortion and discriminatory differentiation. We recognize that the university is not just its wealthy trustees and administration—many of whom paved the way for Trump's current onslaught with their own repression of campus protests in 2020-2024—but also its students, faculty, staff, alumni, and surrounding communities who share common cause to resist these myriad assaults from above.

It may sometimes feel impossible for our communities to adequately respond to these multiple crises. Overwhelm is indeed part of the far right's strategy to remake the world into a mythic past and an apocalyptic future. But the long arc of global liberation movements teaches us that justice-nurturing practices between learning spaces, communities, and the printed page grow the potential to build alternative approaches to social life. In this spirit, these essays highlight past and present social movement pedagogies and literacies to offer models for how we can get free together. We want to thank our friends and mentors at *JBW* for inviting us to guest-edit this issue, and for all their kind support.

The four of us came together here as current and former educators and students of the City University of New York (CUNY) with a shared commitment to honoring how these activisms play out in writing and classrooms, as well as between the campus and society. We each produced dissertations and related scholarship explicitly centering CUNY and Black, Puerto Rican, and coalitional freedom struggles in the US (Molloy; Reed; Sprauve; Zeemont). When crafting this issue, then, we primarily located our own understand-

ing of writing and education in the work of movement-building. We were particularly inspired by the vibrant counter-institutional legacies of CUNY, through which we have been shaped as students and workers. CUNY's own histories of radicalism and repression offer a prism for navigating this current moment in which the federal government and conservative think tanks are seeking to take over higher education. For instance, in the 1970 context of the Open Admissions struggle, CUNY teacher-writer-activist June Jordan described a philosophy of writing grounded in movement work that resisted the forms and contents of racial capitalism:

Our words must grow. If we abandon language, we will surely abandon the possible meanings of the word humane. . . . Words are the names of history, minute by minute. We must name the history to which we are responsible: We must name ourselves, and we must name the others we must recognize as crucial to the history our lives imply. We stand convicted by the language we employ. We live accessible to love according to the language we invent. We will know each other by our names. Our words must grow. Our eyes have grown. Our words must grow.

We are inspired by the expansive understanding of writing put forth by other queer and BIPOC writer-activists grounded in struggles for just education systems and just worlds, even as these names are not always centered in composition-rhetoric (Pritchard).

In formulating the idea for this special issue, we aimed to place students, activists, and communities as the leading forces of innovative writing practices and pedagogies. These participants are not mere objects of study or, in the case of the latter two, tangential or irrelevant to the more “authoritative,” “objective,” or “informed” ideas of established composition professors or writing program administrators. Writing is not defined by institutions but by those doing it (including, but not limited to, those within institutions). Communities and young people in and beyond the university compose, create, educate, and dream together to forge connections with one another and create new worlds.

### **Weaving Different Narratives Together**

The articles compiled in this issue span institutional, spatial, and temporal contexts. However, beyond a broader shared commitment to trans/counter-disciplinarity and social movement work, we see three major threads

that tie these five articles together. First, each of these pieces draws on recovered or documented history—whether via archival tracing of insurgent writing of past decades or recent student work—as a rhetorical praxis and methodology. Secondly, each of these pieces frames students not as passive subjects of research or in any way “basic,” but rather as people with political and rhetorical power on the front lines of radical thought and writing. Finally, each of these pieces offers a critique of what we call a “containment-conscious” pedagogy/rhetoric, including predatory inclusion (Seamster and Charron-Chénier; Reed; Taylor). These pieces understand that the academy is by default a carceral space animated by the structural logics of colonialism and anti-Blackness (Rodríguez; la paperson), but that it also gathers the fecund collective energies of people who can overturn these logics. Radical students, educators, and community members use writing and other modes of activism to unveil these structures and open up spaces for real critical work in solidarity with one another.

Indeed, in her piece “In Honor of the Earthworm: Pockets of Air for ‘Decolonial Riders’ and Activist Literacies in White Settler Writing Programs and English Departments,” Carmen Kynard writes:

the irony and contradiction of colonial schooling is that it also produces students who strike the empire back. . . . From the moment BIPOC students entered American universities, they have connected oppression on-campus with off-campus social realities and have protested and challenged every hierarchical regime. (17)

Kynard traces her relationship with one such student, whom she calls Haven, whose institutional critique of her campus and program’s anti-Blackness under the thin veneer of “DEI” created “pockets of air” for herself (33). Interweaving her own experiences of composition-rhetoric’s white supremacist logics with Haven’s story, Kynard finds that “turning [her] solidarity toward students like Haven isn’t a difficult choice because [her] own fate is nested with [Haven’s]” (21).

Like Kynard’s piece, Coco, Anna, and Sean’s article “Antiracist Rhetorical Praxis in the 1960s-70s *Tech News/The Paper* at the City College of New York” centers the rhetorical praxes of radical student writer-activists whose writing operates in contradistinction from the kind of rigidly monolingual, whitewashed discourses lauded by the racial-capitalist colonial university. In our historical case study of the birth of the student newspaper *The Paper* from 1966 to 1970 at CUNY’s City College of New York (CCNY), we chronicle how

student journalists deployed antiracist forms and content in a sophisticated and effective example of radical Black and Puerto Rican student literacy. With this story of how *Tech News* became *The Paper*—entwined with how CCNY became Harlem University (albeit temporarily)—we signal to the institutional and interpersonal shifts that the linguistic praxis of working-class Black and Puerto Rican students can imaginatively conjure. We hope this example can be useful to educators, students, and communities who seek not only to oppose monolingual writing testing and teaching systems, but to reinvent sites of learning and literacy.

Meanwhile, Daisy Atterbury's article "Oil/School: Land and Affiliation in the Age of Fossil Ed" centers a different set of counter-institutional student writing to tell a story of the state's conflicting aims. They trace the work of Two Spirit climate activist and former University of New Mexico student, Jonathan Juarez-Alonzo, who led a series of climate strikes in Albuquerque in 2019, supported by thousands of college students. In a 2022 op-ed, Juarez-Alonzo reflected on their decision to leave the university indefinitely: "Students like myself feel our futures are being held hostage: Do we invest in ourselves and take advantage of free higher education? Or should we even be wasting [time] in a classroom when our elected leaders are leading us down a path toward total climate collapse?" (73). Atterbury utilizes Juarez-Alonzo's testimony to underscore that New Mexico offers free tuition (an "Opportunity Scholarship") for all state high-school graduates by relying on the oil and gas industry to bankroll such programs. While activists like Juarez-Alonzo demand that the state protect residents from these industries' devastating environmental impacts, the same industries create "opportunity" for students. Meanwhile, drilling and fracking are prohibited in wealthy, settler-inhabited areas. Atterbury asks us to examine how, *on the same stretch of land*, ecological crises damage the water, land is preserved and protected from drilling, instructors commute to the university because they cannot afford to live in the vicinity, and students get to attend college "for free"—sponsored by settler colonialism. *The vexed story we must tell about land is the story we must learn to tell about ourselves.*

Vani Kannan and Steven Payne also take up the pedagogical and rhetorical significance of landed histories in their article "Community Notes, CUNY & the Bronx County Historical Society Archives." They outline a vibrant effort to activate students and community members as archival workers to recover movement histories from groups like the Young Lords, El Comité, and White Lightning. They also generate attention via the "Hidden Black Histories of the Bronx" project to an African Burial Ground at Van

Cortlandt Park, the former site of a plantation. Reflecting on this project thus far, they observe:

CUNY students and educators have already proven to be incredibly valuable partners in our ongoing efforts to transform The Bronx County Archives into a genuine community archive, not only deeply rooted in community activism and community life but also shaped by and determined by the active contributions and continuing insights of community members. (103)

This outward-facing pedagogy and campus-community collaboration is one that may make hierarchical campus faculty feel “compromised” or decentered—and creates complicities that CUNY administrators may decry as inviting the unsanctioned presence of “outside agitators.” However, this work is vital precisely because it offers an investment in change and community-building that destabilizes neocolonial institutional positionalities in favor of different structures of care.

Finally, Javiela Evangelista’s piece “Activating Legacies of Freedom to Transform Economies of Prestige in Academia and Ourselves” expresses how invested community members, educators, and students can resist within the neoliberal university to embrace relations beyond its limits. For Evangelista, legacies of freedom refer to historical figures, texts, and social justice activism that resist structural oppression, which serve as both a political and pedagogical praxis. She invites us to activate legacies of freedom through “liberation literacies,” antiracist practices, Indigenous praxis, and fugitive pedagogies (108). In dialogue with scholars Jamila Lyiscott, Lorgia García-Peña, and others, Evangelista deconstructs the power of language in the classroom via the exploration of liberation literacies. How does our reception of “home languages” in the classroom as instructors engage or squelch legacies of freedom (115)? Ultimately, Evangelista asks us to use legacies of freedom in order to “pause for openings” (117) in the space of the university, which is often invested in the plunder and profit we frequently associate with big business. Though the political (and pedagogical) environments in which we live can feel totalizing, this essay reminds us that together, we can “pause” (117), use our home languages in class, and make emancipatory openings much wider.

## Basic Writing's Troubled History and Painful Legacy

The history and legacy of Writing Studies—including “Basic Writing” studies—are inevitably enmeshed in the flows of revolution and counter-revolution unveiled by the pieces above. The logics of containment that we see in the current-day repression of writing and language are not new, but are grounded in supremacist ideologies of literacy and schooling that emerged in the counter-insurgency of the wake of the Civil Rights Movement. We agree with Kynard’s frustration with “the ways that rhetoric-compositionists are so complacent about the white colonization of writing instruction while proclaiming a commitment to democratic classrooms and progressive pedagogies” (15). With this in mind, as *JBW* prepares to observe its fifty-year anniversary, and as we add our voices to its pages, we also feel we should briefly address *JBW*’s troubled history and painful legacy.

As Sean, Coco, and Anna note in our article in this issue, Mina Shaughnessy between 1967 and 1978 developed and promoted the idea that a distinct pedagogy of “Basic Writing” formalism could benefit some imagined group of “Basic Writers”—often measured by shallow and invalid writing tests focused on small sentence errors. In 1975, “Error” was the theme and the subtitle of the very first *JBW* issue, including Shaughnessy’s argument as editor and founder for the existence of “diverse” basic writers who were so unprepared for college that teachers were required to return to “an old place,” emphasizing sentence errors (“Introduction” 1–3).

But we affirm here Sean and Alexis Bennett’s 2022 conclusion in their archival study (published in this journal) that Shaughnessy’s original 1970s Basic Writing program was

in fact a pedagogical white backlash to integration that segregated Black and Brown writing students into remedial courses, created barriers to their success, and denigrated them as “less than” other students—all in ways that were carefully obscured with euphemisms and codes. Basic Writing falsely equated integration and remediation by simply recasting writing courses for Black and Brown writing students as the original “basic writers.” In no sense was this terrible harm accidental or truly innocent. Racism was not an accidental, unintended consequence in the original version of Basic Writing: it was instead its principal intended feature. (30)

Moreover, we agree with Sean and Alexis that while Shaughnessy’s specific Basic Writing narrative, “offered in similar forms from 1971 to 1978,” has since “grown larger and more complex. . . core and troubling elements of the original Basic Writing narrative have not changed since 1975—and

cannot change within this paradigm” (n.1, 30).

We also recognize the often complex and subtle ways that “Basic Writing” continues to harm us today, as Sean, Silvester Fonville, and Abdus Salam explored in their 2020 archival history, validity inquiry, and case study (published in this journal):

so long as college writing programs and teachers define their work by searching out and measuring student deficits—by finding ways to argue that some incoming college students (like Sil and Abdus) are more “basic,” less able, less likely to succeed, and less valued than others, colleges will fall short of their mission to fight for racial and social justice. The poisoned trees planted four or five decades ago will not be fully rooted out. . . Reduced harm is still harm. Reduced indignity is still indignity. In the end, we must oppose, rethink and reimagine these biased old legacy systems until the day sometime soon when they are all ‘eliminated root and branch.’ (27)

The history and discursive politics of “Basic Writing” reveal the stronghold that top-down, deficit-oriented frameworks have long had on disciplinary conceptions of writing, which has had very real, harmful, material effects for fifty years and counting (Zeemont).

Soon after Shaughnessy’s death in 1978, *JBW* was reorganized into an independent peer-reviewed journal. From then until now, its editorial stance on Basic Writing pedagogies has been open to different views. *JBW* has published some articles criticizing systems that test and label some college writing students as “basic” (Lu; Jones; Shor; Molloy, Fonville, and Salam; Molloy and Bennett). Among these was Min-Zhan Lu’s groundbreaking critique of Shaughnessy’s politics of “white innocence,” which remains one of the most powerful indictments of disciplinary and institutional white supremacy in composition-rhetoric. It was also in *JBW* in 1997 that Ira Shor famously labeled CUNY’s Basic Writing and testing systems as a form of apartheid (Shor).

But *JBW* has also published many articles arguing *for* those very same segregationist premises and systems (see Greenberg; Laurence; Rondinone). In the backdrop of these *JBW* dialogues, radical students (such as the activist group SLAM/Student Liberation Action Movement), faculty, and community members were engaging in their own conversations and protests fighting the elimination of “remedial classes” and the targeted push-out of students the Black, Brown, and working-class students enrolled in them. Meanwhile,

the state, city and affiliated neoliberal think tanks used the rhetorics of minoritized students' "basic"-ness as a strategy to legitimize pedagogies of containment and racial-colonial dispossession on and off campus (Zeemont). And "an unavoidable implied meta-argument in a journal (and in a field) that still keeps the name 'Basic Writing' is that the enterprise of determining which entering college students are more 'basic' than others. . . continues to have arguable merit" (Molloy and Bennett 29).

As they contend with the troubled history and painful legacy of "Basic Writing," we know our colleagues at *JBW* have long rejected the idea that "basic writers" exist. They know that writing pedagogies and testing instruments grounded in racist and colonial formalism are incompetent, biased, and harmful. They teach, research, edit, and write to promote justice in writing instruction, just as we hope to do with this issue. That is why they have supported our issue and why we have agreed to join them here.

### **Continuations**

When thinking of teacher-activists in the fields of critical pedagogy and Writing Studies, scholars may tend to reach for the same handful of names. While these figures are important, when we consider the praxes that inspire us to reshape the form of the writing classroom, we think of those who taught and learned through Black freedom struggles. We think of Septima Clark, a lifelong teacher and member of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference; Ella Baker, a field secretary for the NAACP and lead facilitator of SNCC; and Bernice Robinson, a hairdresser-turned-educator in the Sea Island Citizenship Schools (Sprauve). We think of the student-teachers who traveled to Mississippi in the summer of 1964 to teach in outdoor classrooms, churches, and homes. We think of a young Kwame Ture (Stokely Carmichael) who asked Freedom Summer students to question why they believed their use of Black Language was wrong. We think of desks forming a U-shape and students opening up class singing spirituals. We think about how no writing these students produced would be "basic" to them. Such teacher-activists formed a rhetorical educational praxis that is part of the foundation of critical pedagogy, but moreover, their pedagogical and political work serves as a critical launchpad for the social justice work of today's writing instructors and scholars. The work presented in this issue furthers the political project of these essential educators.

This issue's contributors tangle with the harmful systems described above, grounding some of their theories in essential historical context.



Coco, Anna, and Sean describe how the unsung interventions of Black and Puerto Rican City College student journalists altered the political conditions and institutional directions of CUNY, even if their story was obscured by a countervailing literacy legacy based on the perceived errors of “basic writers.” Kynard discusses how the understanding of humanities in the academy cannot be stretched if institutional anti-Blackness is perpetuated in these spaces, while Kannan and Payne reveal how historical archives often exclude BIPOC and poor and working populations. In both of these pieces, the function of history is clear. For Kynard, these academic fields have traditionally lionized a sliver of (read: white) thinkers and theorists, and “antiracist” methods to address this historical trend fall short, as many administrators and educators in the academy will not commit to a true divestment from pedagogical instruments rooted in racial oppression. Kannan and Payne, meanwhile, underscore the importance of archival recovery in documenting the lives of Black and Brown Bronxites. Because their documentation is community-based, their writing shines a light on lives outside of the classroom. These pieces point to racialized absences inherent in the institution (including in its own chronology of social uplift) and spotlight the theory and praxis that explode these instruments of oppression.

Atterbury reminds us that “history is storytelling” (73), while Evangelista asserts that “economies of prestige” present in the university need to be transformed (105). Atterbury—as well as Coco, Anna, and Sean—argue that while some “stories” become enshrined in the academy as theory (73), other narratives (read: narratives by nonwhite storytellers) are relegated to the edges and borders. Atterbury highlights how the university’s political (and pedagogical) act of containment often stands at odds with the needs of its students. The stories that exist on the periphery are not “basic” or in need of correction. Instead, they act as a corrective, much like the Bronx-based archive Kannan and Payne offer; the pages of *The Paper* that Coco, Anna, and Sean lift up; and the “endarkened politics” Kynard exhorts us to practice (16). Evangelista underlines the summoning of “ancestral legacies of freedom” (108) as an essential feature of liberation within and outside of the academy. She argues that institutional “economies of prestige” can be ruptured via the exploration of student-produced work that engages their immediate community (109). Like the other contributors, Evangelista understands that the chronicle is key to mapping the stories sitting on the edge; it is the key to recognizing that what has been historically understood to be “basic” is rather complex.

For all of our contributors, historicity operates in the foreground of

their work. We too believe that the exploration of history indispensably functions as rhetorical praxis, and is indeed a precondition for developing strategic directions to transform our present catastrophes. In a social and political landscape that is attempting to close the door on thorough “case studies” of all kinds on the path to obstructing all thoughtful approaches to compassionate co-existence, acknowledging the primacy of historical context in our scholarship is more crucial than ever. Those who wish to erase from our curricula the liberation-focused studies that were born out of effective coalitional struggles a half-century ago demonstrate exactly how deeply these movements re-shaped our social consciousness across generations. If the pedagogical and political lineages celebrated in this special issue were not so dangerous to the present neo-fascist regime, why would they be under such intensified attack?

Our work as scholars and teachers of writing is not discrete from these larger political dynamics. In spite of the atmosphere of academic repression and the administrative impulse to curtail our political imagination, becoming silent and capitulating to depoliticized pedagogical and theoretical frameworks “will not protect” us, as CUNY poet-activist-educator Audre Lorde reminds us (40). Now is the time to follow the lead of movement workers and eschew the race- and power-evasive frameworks and theories of change historically entrenched in our very fields of scholarship (Fitzsimmons and Prasad; Kynard, *Vernacular*).

Against the lure of cynical despair about the inevitability of far right fever dreams, or the hollow promise of blinkered solutions to reclaim a social order (or university model) that has dehumanized and impoverished so many, we urge readers to be inspired by these essays and invent new directions for our shared story. With so much at stake, may we embark on different journeys of study and struggle—across our universities and communities—that can grow our words (and actions!) toward transformative collective change.

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